Compositional Processes as Graph

Semantic Modelling and Terminology in the Anton Webern Gesamtausgabe (AWG)

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ABSTRACT: Compositional processes rarely form a linear sequence, yet editions have to put them in some order, and formal models make every relation explicit. This paper asks how a digital edition can represent non-linear processes while keeping its claims as open as the evidence allows.

The Anton Webern Gesamtausgabe (AWG), a hybrid print and online edition, models Webern's sources, work stages and contextual information as an RDF-based knowledge graph. This graph combines data generated from the edition with assertions curated by the editors, so it shows where editorial judgment comes into play. The paper uses it as a methodological laboratory. It argues that the central categories of research on Webern's compositional processes come less from theoretical frameworks than from the idiosyncrasies of his documents and from the editorial practices shaped by them. It then examines what happens to these categories once they are encoded as classes and relations, and how the model keeps uncertainty and simultaneity expressible.

The paper also asks what can be transferred to other repertoires and research traditions, and where frictions specific to Webern, to notation or to the medium appear. Existing standards from cultural heritage and music serve as points of alignment rather than as the model itself. Where model and data do not fit, the mismatch is itself informative: it shows the places where the graph refuses to claim more than the sources support.

Rather than a full model of genetic criticism, the AWG offers an experimental, operational framework, one in which model and data shape each other. This raises the question of whose genetic order such a graph finally shows.

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